Hard Magic and Soft Magic in Chronicles of Darkness



Second Chances
Member

Join Date: Dec 2014
Posts: 4201

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Hard Magic and Soft Magic in Chronicles of Darkness

#1
02-20-2018, 09:09 AM

Howdy. As I'm prone to do, I was binging storytelling videos on youtube right as Hello Future Me posted his analysis of **Hard** and **Soft** magic systems. My first thought ran to RPGs (Werewolf the Forsaken specifically), thinking that since this was a tabletop game, the magic system must be diamond hard. As I watch more though, I realized that while there are hard rules in every gameline, within those rules there is lots of latitude for making new powers and abilities, which is a characteristic of a soft magic system. Since different gamelines may have different characteristics of each magic system, I thought it may be interesting to open it up for discussion.

How hard or soft is the magic system in each CofD gameline? Do they vary from game to game?

Chris H/EndDaysEngine | Patreon| He/His | Currently Writing: *[Redacted], [Redacted]*

CofD booklists: Beast I Changeling | Demon | Deviant | Geist I Hunter I Mage | Mummy | Promethean | Vampire | Werewolf

Tags: None

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02-20-2018, 10:11 AM #2

From what I see, considering that we are talking about magic in an rpg system, all gamelines have an "hard magic" system. They have weaknesses, limitations and costs. Even the more flexible systems are hard, for even mages know what



LostLight
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they can or can not do (you can't cast Death magic using Forces Arcana, for example). Understanding magic out of character is integral for using it in a game, both as protagonist and antagonist.

Check my STV content, Or My Homebrew

"And all our knowledge is, Ourselves to know"- An Essay on Man

I now blog in here

3

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02-20-2018, 10:32 AM #3



Morangias
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 1670

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When you create or improvise a new effect in a soft magic system, you do it because you're a magic user and magic can do anything.

When you create or improvise a new effect in a hard magic system, you do it because your understanding of the rules of magic tells you it should work, or you found a loophole in existing rules (possibly with a heavy cost involved) or even because your superior understanding tells you the thing everyone thought impossible is actually possible if done the right way.

As such, all magic systems available for player use in CofD (and most those antagonist-only as well) are hard magic systems. The only exceptions are the entities which explicitly operate at plot level, generally limited to Rank 6+ ephemeral beings and some big cosmic beings such as the God-Machine, Principle, Exarchs/Oracles and such.

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02-20-2018, 11:37 AM #4



Second Chances
Member

Join Date: Dec 2014
Posts: 4201

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> *Originally posted by **Morangias***
> *When you create or improvise a new effect in a soft magic system, you do it because you're a magic user and magic can do anything.*
>
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I mostly agree with that sentiment and I agree that CofD is hard, but I still see some softness. Take the Lodge of the Mourners for example. The ability to vomit up spiritsor shunt curses onto those who've eaten the Mourner's flesh isn't predicted by any preexisting system. Its just something that the Mourners are able to do. The execution of how those systems function is hard, but they aren't exactly predictable from a Werewolf's usual abilities, which (to me at least) seems to add some softness.

Chris H/EndDaysEngine | Patreon| He/His | Currently Writing: *[Redacted], [Redacted]*

CofD booklists: Beast I Changeling | Demon | Deviant | Geist I Hunter I Mage | Mummy | Promethean | Vampire | Werewolf

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02-20-2018, 12:04 PM #5



Morangias
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 1670

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*Originally posted by **Second Chances***

I mostly agree with that sentiment and I agree that CofD is hard, but I still see some softness. Take the Lodge of the Mourners for example. The ability to vomit up spiritsor shunt curses onto those who've eaten the Mourner's flesh isn't predicted by any preexisting system. Its just something that the Mourners are able to do. The execution of how those systems function is hard, but they aren't exactly predictable from a Werewolf's usual abilities, which (to me at least) seems to add some softness.

Soft/Hard magic is a hard divide, not a matter of degrees. Either magic has rules (in which case it's a hard system) or it can do whatever the hell the author wants (soft system).

Z-splats are specifically meant to introduce weird abilities that often don't have much to do with the usual fare of the splat, be they Lodges, Bloodlines or what have you. The very fact that they bend the rules is codified within the rules.

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02-20-2018, 12:16 PM #6



ArcaneArts
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 11382

*Originally posted by **Morangias***

Soft/Hard magic is a hard divide, not a matter of degrees. Either magic has rules (in which case it's a hard system) or it can do whatever the hell the author wants (soft system).

Z-splats are specifically meant to introduce weird abilities that often don't have much to do with the usual fare of the splat, be they Lodges, Bloodlines or what have you. The very fact that they bend the rules is codified within the rules.

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THat's a bit of crass approach. You can apply a seive to any principle created and break it down into finer forms, until granular threads becomes the whole of reality. You can also calcify things up to certain thicknesses and hardnesses.

Yes, the general idea of hard and soft implies a hard divide, but any close examination of example sets within either reveals that some soft magic systems are harder than others, and visa versa with hards. Reality abhors absolutes, and authors are bound to those same principles.

Last edited by ArcaneArts; 02-20-2018, 12:30 PM.

Kelly R.S. Steele, Freelance Writer(Feel free to call me Kelly, Arcane, or Arc)
The world is not beautiful, therefore it is.-Keiichi Sigsawa, Kino's Journey
Feminine pronouns, please.

4
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Second Chances
Member

Join Date: Dec 2014
Posts: 4201

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02-20-2018, 12:42 PM #7

> *Originally posted by* ***ArcaneArts***
> *THat's a bit of crass approach. You can apply a seive to any principle created and break it down into finer forms, until granular threads becomes the whole of reality. You can also calcify things up to certain thicknesses and hardnesses.*
>
> *Yes, the general idea of hard and soft implies a hard divide, but any close examination of example sets within either reveals that some soft magic systems are harder than others, and visa versa with hards. Reality abhors absolutes, and authors are bound to those same principles.*

Pretty much all of this. Its easy to create a dichotomy out of hard and soft magic, but this is pretty clearly a scale. Fullmetal Alchemistis would clearly be on the hard side, Lord of the Rings would be soft, but where is Harry Potter? The rules of what HP magic can do aren't super well defined. Magic can do pretty much anything, with a few exceptions. On the other hand, the how of Harry Potter is extremely well defined, characters have to learn and practice magic (not pull it out of their asses), and the limits of what magic can't do are pretty hard. Is Harry Potter hard or soft? It probably lands on the softer side, but it is still much harder than Lord of the Rings.

Chris H/EndDaysEngine | **Patreon**| **He/His** | **Currently Writing**: *[Redacted], [Redacted]*

CofD booklists: Beast I Changeling | Demon | Deviant | Geist I Hunter I Mage | Mummy | Promethean | Vampire | Werewolf

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Morangias
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 1670

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02-20-2018, 12:58 PM #8

Yeah, I just re-read Sanderson's essay on the subject, and clearly I didn't remember it as well as I thought. I stand corrected.

I still don't think Z-splats serve to soften their respective magic systems, because the variation they allow for is written into the system from the get go. I'd say the primary "softening factor", if you will, for CofD magic (not counting the plot device-level beings I mentioned before) is the fact that there are roughly a hundred different magic systems in the setting, with different and often mutually contradictory rules.

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Second Chances
Member

Join Date: Dec 2014
Posts: 4201

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02-20-2018, 01:06 PM #9

> *Originally posted by* ***Morangias***
> *Yeah, I just re-read Sanderson's essay on the subject, and clearly I didn't remember it as well as I thought. I stand corrected.*
>
> *I still don't think Z-splats serve to soften their respective magic systems, because the variation they allow for is written into the system from the get go. I'd say the primary "softening factor", if you will, for CofD magic (not counting the plot device-level beings I mentioned before) is the fact that there are roughly a hundred different magic systems in the setting, with different and often mutually contradictory rules.*

Yeah, I'd agree with that. I wasn't targeting the Lodge of Mourners because it was a Z-splat, just that it was easiest example of out of left field magic I could link to.

Chris H/EndDaysEngine | **Patreon**| **He/His** | **Currently Writing**: *[Redacted], [Redacted]*

CofD booklists: Beast I Changeling | Demon | Deviant | Geist I Hunter I Mage | Mummy | Promethean | Vampire | Werewolf

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Heavy Arms

02-20-2018, 01:08 PM #10

Edit: Sorry, slow to type apparently. Got ninjaed on some of this, but I'm feel a bit lazy about rewriting it all.

Well... no... the Hard/Soft divide @Second Chances is basing things on is not a binary, but a spectrum. The videos in question use Harry Potter as an example of something that's very much in the middle. The Potterverse looks solidly hard

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Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 12634

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magic on the surface (wave a spell and speak the incantation, thus X happens), a deeper look shows a lot of soft elements as well, because the audience never really knows why Potterverse magic is the way it is, and how to slot in all the exceptions that aren't explained. For example, some people in Potterverse are parcelmouths. Why? Nobody knows. It's just a thing that happens. This is clearly soft magic. The Potterverse magic is primarily accessed in hard magic ways, but is effectively soft at its core as for inexplicable reasons (beyond authorial intent) those rules get broken all the time; leaving the true capabilities and limitations of magic unknown.

Most (though not all) RPGs do fall on the hard side of things, simply because designing a game set in a magical world otherwise is incredibly difficult. The CofD is definitely on the hard side of the spectrum, though not 100% as the general setting of the CofD allows for plenty of soft magic elements (esp. in ST controlled major NPCs).

To the original question, the major player characters, regardless of flexibility are generally all equally hard magic in design. The best sources of soft magic for players are in the minor templates and Hunter: the Vigil. A lot of Endowments are very soft, because Hunter's limitations allow the game to follow the "Arthurian" approach to soft magic pointed out in the videos. Just as we need no real explanation of how Excalibur works, came into being, or why in any given telling of the King Arthur Story, Endowments can be very vague, because the players are only going to be dealing with the specific power or handful of special items they'll get.

Similarly, I expect Deviant to be a CofD game actually on the soft side of the spectrum because - again - it doesn't really matter. Renegades have the powers that they have, so they don't need a larger hard framework to explain it all into.

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02-21-2018, 09:43 AM #11



Morangias
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 1670

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> *Originally posted by **Heavy Arms***
> *To the original question, the major player characters, regardless of flexibility are generally all equally hard magic in design. The best sources of soft magic for players are in the minor templates and Hunter: the Vigil. A lot of Endowments are very soft, because Hunter's limitations allow the game to follow the "Arthurian" approach to soft magic pointed out in the videos. Just as we need no real explanation of how Excalibur works, came into being, or why in any given telling of the King Arthur Story, Endowments can be very vague, because the players are only going to be dealing with the specific power or handful of special items they'll get.*
>
> *Similarly, I expect Deviant to be a CofD game actually on the soft side of the spectrum because - again - it doesn't really matter. Renegades have the powers that they have, so they don't need a larger hard framework to explain it all into.*

This, I'm pretty sure, is incorrect. By necessity, all magic available to playable splats is gonna be right up there in the hardest part of the spectrum, because it's specifically designed to solve problems in the story, and as such, needs to be proportionately explained.

I think the confusion is between how well the magic is explained IC vs OOC.

Sanderson's First Law, the way he himself phrased it, states:

> *An author's ability to solve conflict with magic is DIRECTLY PROPORTIONAL to how well the reader understands said magic.*

(source)

Notably, the law concerns itself with the author and the reader and not with the people inside the story. From the readers' perspective, all player-available magic in CofD is strictly codified in terms of game rules.

Also notably, Sanderson later specifies in his essay that the part that needs to be understood is what the magic can do, not its origins in the world of the story. This is, again, exactly the part every magic system of CofD, from the Supernatural Merits in the black corebook to Disciplines to Arcana to Endowments to however the Deviant powers are gonna be called, explains well due to the necessities of the medium. We may not know how vampires came into being, but we sure do have a very good idea of what they can do and at what cost. We need not understand the weird science behind Valkyrie's gadgets to know their capabilities in no uncertain terms.

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Heavy Arms
Banned

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 12634

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02-21-2018, 11:59 AM #12

> *Originally posted by **Morangias***
> *This, I'm pretty sure, is incorrect. By necessity, all magic available to playable splats is gonna be right up there in the hardest part of the spectrum, because it's specifically designed to solve problems in the story, and as such, needs to be proportionately explained.*
> *...*
> *Notably, the law concerns itself with the author and the reader and not with the people inside the story. From the readers' perspective, all player-available magic in CofD is strictly codified in terms of game rules*

But the magic of Hunter and many of the minor templates isn't well explained, precisely because it isn't there to solve problems.

Endowments and minor template Merit powers are, generally speaking, too weak in the CofD to solve problems in the sense Sanderson is using. They're ultimately just tools to elevate those characters high enough that their individual talents can solve problems in a realm of conflict they'd be too overwhelmed by without a tool.

A silver bullet doesn't solve the problem of "werewolves." It gives a normal person a chance in solving the problem of "werewolves" using physical violence. The magic of that might need to be thoroughly explored in a hard way when playing Werewolf, but it doesn't if you're just playing normal people running into the supernatural. It can be soft in Hunter, because again, it doesn't solve the problem by itself.

I think you're overstating things with RPGs when you say things are codified in rules, thus must be hard magic. The "reader's ability to understand said magic," doesn't mean that they can't have some of the rules of magic. There aren't really rules for how Cheiron Group creates Thaumatech. We don't know how any of that works. We don't really know why it works. And it isn't codified in the mechanics. All we as the readers know, is the rules for the agents that have implants and how they can take advantage of that.

You're basically saying that because the readers know that if a normal person in

Middle Earth puts on the One Ring, they turn invisible, then the Middle Earth stories are all hard magic; that one tiny application of magic that the reader is thorough familiar with and understands turns the whole thing hard. Even though we never know the full extent of the One Ring's power (we're told repeatedly that it can do a lot more than that, and we know it corrupts people in some vague way, and extends life in some fashion that isn't really clear), we know enough about how it works for the characters that use it, that we don't violate Sanderson's first law.

The same is true with minor templates, Endowments, and from the previews Deviants. The players only understand a fraction of the magic to play, because they only need to get the tiny part that their character's use.

And your stance is still very binary rather than spectrum. I'm not saying these parts of the CofD are 100% soft magic, just that the games generally lean on the hard side, but these are exceptions that lean to the soft.

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Charlaquin
Member
★★★★★
Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 10831

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02-21-2018, 12:40 PM #13

It's also worth noting that Sanderson was talking about writing, not games. A game requires a certain degree of hardness in its magic mechanics in order for the players to effectively manipulate them. But that doesn't need to have any bearing on the way the magic is written within the story.

Using the CofD line I am most familiar with as an example, the magic of vampiric disciplines is pretty rock hard *as a game mechanic*. The player knows exactly what their character is capable of. They know there are 10 standard disciplines, each with 5 levels of mastery, and the specific effects of each level, plus two forms of blood sorcery, which follows its own set of rules and each has rituals with specific effects, and coils of the dragon. As players, we all know exactly how to execute all of these magical elements within the rules of the game. But from a *writing* standpoint, is it really all that well understood? In novels and short stories set in the Requiem universe, the rules of the magic system are often quite a lot softer. It's generally understood that vampires' powers fall into the broad categories of manipulating minds, manipulating emotions, manipulating perceptions, enhancing physical abilities, and blood magic. And it's generally understood which clans are most known for which kind of magic. It's generally known that older or more experienced vampires can do more impressive things with their powers. But it doesn't get talked about in the same terms as it does in the rules. Vampires don't think of Disciplines as one of 10 specific collections of powers on a 1 to 5 scale. They don't think of Vitae costs in specific numbers. Heck, it's said that in Rome, the Julii didn't even realize they were using magic, they just thought people followed their orders because that was the natural way of things.

So, I think it's very possible for magic systems to be hard in terms of game mechanics and soft in terms of narrative. This is one of the ways that games differ from books as a storytelling medium. In a game, a magic system has the luxury of being as narratively soft as it wants, while still being able to solve problems without breaking Sanderson's First Law, because unlike a novel, a game can communicate to its audience outside of the narrative, through its mechanics. The audience can understand perfectly how the magic works mechanically, while not having a clue how it works narratively, and generally won't feel cheated by its ability to solve problems.

Going by Willow now, or Wil for short. She/Her/Hers.

4

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02-21-2018, 12:53 PM #14



Morangias
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 1670

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> *Originally posted by* ***Heavy Arms***
> *But the magic of Hunter and many of the minor templates isn't well explained, precisely because it isn't there to solve problems.*

Sorry, but that's just wrong. I don't really have any argument to back it up, because it's blindingly obvious that Endowments are functional magic meant to be directly applied to problems.

> *Endowments and minor template Merit powers are, generally speaking, too weak in the CofD to solve problems in the sense Sanderson is using. They're ultimately just tools to elevate those characters high enough that their individual talents can solve problems in a realm of conflict they'd be too overwhelmed by without a tool.*
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And here you're admitting it yourself - Endowments are a tool. Quoth Sanderson:

> *If the reader understands how the magic works, then you can use the magic (or, rather, the characters using the magic) to solve problems. In this case, it's not the magic mystically making everything better. Instead, it's the characters' wit and experience that solves the problems. Magic becomes another tool—and, like any other tool, its careful application can enhance the character and the plot.*

Magic being a tool is, again, a staple of hard magic systems. It doesn't matter that these particular tools are inefficient compared to tools of other splats.

> *I think you're overstating things with RPGs when you say things are codified in rules, thus must be hard magic. The "reader's ability to understand said magic," doesn't mean that they can't have some of the rules of magic. There aren't really rules for how Cheiron Group creates Thaumatech. We don't know how any of that works. We don't really know why it works. And it isn't codified in the mechanics. All we as the readers know, is the rules for the agents that have implants and how they can take advantage of that.*

And - again - according to Sanderson himself, the origins of magic are the last thing that matters. We don't need to know how Cheiron does their stuff, as long as their stuff produces reliable, quantifiable results.

And yes, as long as magic in a roleplaying game is described with a set of game rules, it is hard magic. Which isn't to say you can't have soft magic in roleplaying games - but then, you can't really have magic users as playable types, because

the gist of Sanderson's Law is that in a soft magic setting, magic becomes an asspull and you don't want your story conflict to be solved by asspulls.

> *You're basically saying that because the readers know that if a normal person in Middle Earth puts on the One Ring, they turn invisible, then the Middle Earth stories are all hard magic; that one tiny application of magic that the reader is thorough familiar with and understands turns the whole thing hard. Even though we never know the full extent of the One Ring's power (we're told repeatedly that it can do a lot more than that, and we know it corrupts people in some vague way, and extends life in some fashion that isn't really clear), we know enough about how it works for the characters that use it, that we don't violate Sanderson's first law.*

> *The same is true with minor templates, Endowments, and from the previews Deviants. The players only understand a fraction of the magic to play, because they only need to get the tiny part that their character's use.*

But that "fraction" is actually the entirety of it!

...okay, let's put it differently: what do **you** think is missing from Endowments to classify them as hard magic? I've already shown that their overall power/efficiency level doesn't count.

> *And your stance is still very binary rather than spectrum. I'm not saying these parts of the CofD are 100% soft magic, just that the games generally lean on the hard side, but these are exceptions that lean to the soft.*

I'm not saying CofD is 100% hard. What I am saying is, you picked a wrong example to show its softer side.

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Charlaquin
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 10831

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02-21-2018, 01:49 PM #15

Let's set CofD aside for a moment. Look at Star Wars. The Force is extremely soft as a magic system. Sure, we might know a few common elements of force power - telekinesis, mind tricks, and sometimes shooting lightning if you're evil. It also has some very vaguely defined and inconsistent perceptive abilities involving searching or reaching out with one's feelings. Apparently it's an energy that surrounds, penetrates, and binds the universe together. Except when it's microorganisms in your cells. And it has a will of its own. Except when it doesn't. Not the softest of magic systems, but generally pretty soft.

The force doesn't stop being a soft magic system when you make a Star Wars video game and attatch it to a bunch of systems, with force meters, and light and dark side points, and specifically defined powers with specific effects within the rules that govern the video game. We, as players, understand that these systems are necessary abstractions of the soft magic system that is the force, required to allow us to manipulate it within the rigid system of rules that a computer is capable of understanding and executing. Likewise, when you play one of the various Star Wars tabletop RPGs, the hardness of the game mechanics governing force use are understood to be an abstraction, and not a precise representation of the rules that govern the Force within the fiction of the Star

Wars universe. That doesn't change the fact that the Force is a pretty soft magic system overall.

Again, we're trying to apply a concept that was invented for analysis of written fiction to the medium of games. Magic hardness and softness as Sanderson described it has to be understood in terms of the narrative, not the mechanics, because he was writing about narratives.

Going by Willow now, or Wil for short. She/Her/Hers.

👍 6

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